THE FIRST RENAISSANCE MAN

The term Renaissance man was coined to describe the genius of Leonardo da Vinci. He was a man of so many accomplishments in so many areas of human endeavour that his like has rarely been seen in human history. Casual patrons of the arts know him as the painter of "La Gioconda" - more commonly called the "Mona Lisa" - and of the exquisite "Last Supper", which is painted on the wall of the dining hall in a monastery in Milan. These paintings alone would have assured him enduring fame as an artist, but they should not obscure the fact that he was also a sculptor, an architect, and a man of science who did serious investigations into the natural and physical sciences, mathematics, mechanics, and engineering. More than 300 years before flying machines were perfected, Leonardo had devised plans for prototypes of an airplane and a helicopter. His extensive studies of human anatomy were portrayed in anatomical drawings, which were among the most significant achievements of Renaissance science. His remarkable illustrations of the human body elevated drawing into a means of scientific investigation and exposition, and provided the basic principles for modern scientific illustration.

EXERCISE 1: Find words or phrases in the passage which mean the same as:

COLUMN A **COLUMN B**

a) a man with many abilities in diverse fields *(phrase)* .....

b) achievement .....

c) things people try to do *(phrase)* .....

d) an equal .....

e) informal; non-professional; untrained .....

f) one who supports artistic activity *(phrase)* .....

g) extremely beautiful, delicate, or sensitive .....

h) guarantee [verb] .....

i) make unclear; hide .....

j) an artist who makes statues .....

k) an early model, usually experimental, of something .....

l) (be) demonstrated; (be) depicted .....

m) a drawing or picture for giving an example or explanation of something .....

n) increase someone or something in status or importance .....

o) a detailed explanation of something .....

EXERCISE 2: Choose the correct answer according to the passage.

1. Da Vinci's achievements in the arts . . . . . .

A) made it unnecessary for him to work in science
B) prevented people from taking his medical achievements seriously
C) demonstrate only one of his many and varied talents
D) helped him finance his revolutionary work in aeronautics
E) were of a higher quality than his work in the field of physics

2. In the field of aeronautics, da Vinci . . . . . .

A) was the first man to construct a working airplane or helicopter
B) built the first working models of machines used for human flight
C) developed a couple of flying machines, but they were far from perfect
D) designed flying machines centuries before anyone actually built them
E) used his artistic talents to make some of the most beautiful planes ever

3. Da Vinci's work on human anatomy . . . . . .

A) allowed for great advancement in the field of medicine
B) provided illustrations still used by doctors in the 20th century
C) were important because they were done during the Renaissance
D) came from his desire to paint people with greater accuracy
E) increased the importance of drawing in the scientific process

EXERCISE 3: Complete the sentences by selecting words from Column B in EXERCISE 1.

1. Modern developments have……many charming views in this once spectacular and picturesque town.
2. It was quite convenient that the instructions for the bookcase contained ……as well as words - I couldn't read them as I don't know any Japanese, but by using the pictures, I had no problem putting it together.
3. Before 1991, many people had never even heard of Kuwait, but the fact that a large war was fought over it……its status among world nations and now everyone knows of its existence.
4. My brother has……me a job as a secretary in his accounting firm, but I'm not certain that I want to work in such a tedious job.
5. Hitler was a very charismatic figure who used his ability to control people to cause untold destruction. Hopefully his……will never be seen again, as the world can't handle another person like him.